

FOLK CALM CULTURAL ARCHIVE

The Folk Calm Kitchen

Food traditions and household practices

Measurements, methods, histories, and traditional effects



DIGITAL READING EDITION

folkcalm.com

The record and the reconstruction

Historical sources rarely use the gram scales and kitchen timers found in a modern home. This edition therefore keeps two kinds of information separate. The history and source trail describe where a food or practice was recorded. The quantities and timings are standardized household reconstructions created so the reader can understand the action clearly and repeat the lower-risk preparations.

WHAT IS MEASURED

Ingredient weights, water volume, preparation time, heat level, vessel choice, and visible signs of completion. Food pages are written for a small household batch.

WHAT THE EFFECT LINE MEANS

The traditional effect line states the concrete function historically attributed to the preparation or practice. It records traditional use, not a promised result for every reader, and it is not a substitute for professional care.

A practical boundary

Food pages can be followed as written when the ingredients are suitable for the reader. Household pages involving heat, strong scent, skin contact, wild plants, or old cleaning materials include a caution line. Persistent symptoms, severe pain, breathing difficulty, serious burns, infection, or an allergic reaction do not belong in a household experiment.

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PART I

Food Traditions

Measured household preparations set beside their regional and written histories.



Fried Rice Water

Chao Mi Shui

HISTORICAL RECORD

Rice was often dry-toasted before water was added when a household wanted a thin drink with more aroma than plain rice water. Versions appear in southern and central Chinese home cooking, where the degree of browning changed from family to family.

RECORD TRAIL

Regional household cookery; the measurements are a modern single-pot reconstruction.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 60 g short-grain rice
- 900 ml water
- 6 g brown sugar, optional

TOTAL TIME

About 35 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally served as a light, warming drink when appetite was poor or the stomach felt unsettled.

CAUTION

This is still a rice drink and is not suitable as the only source of food or fluid during persistent illness.

METHOD

- 1 Rinse the rice once and drain it very well.
- 2 Toast it in a dry heavy pan over medium-low heat for 8 to 10 minutes, stirring until most grains are pale gold.
- 3 Add the water, bring to a boil, then simmer gently for 20 minutes.
- 4 Strain for a clear drink or leave a spoonful of softened rice in each cup. Add sugar only after the heat is off.

Kudzu Starch Bowl

Ge Fen Geng

HISTORICAL RECORD

Kudzu root was steamed and eaten in early materia medica records. Tang-period food writing also describes separating the starch and cooking it until translucent. The household bowl remained common wherever kudzu starch was sold as a dry pantry powder.

RECORD TRAIL

The historical trail includes Shi Liao Ben Cao; the gram amounts are a modern kitchen standard.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 25 g food-grade kudzu starch
- 250 ml water
- 8 g honey or rock sugar
- 3 g fresh ginger, optional

TOTAL TIME

About 10 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally associated with easing thirst and providing a soft food during hot weather.

CAUTION

Buy starch labelled for food use. Do not substitute an unidentified wild-root powder.

METHOD

- 1 Mix the starch with 60 ml of the cold water until completely smooth.
- 2 Bring the remaining water to a boil with the ginger, if using, then remove the ginger.
- 3 Pour the boiling water into the starch slurry while stirring continuously.
- 4 Return the mixture to low heat for 1 to 2 minutes until glossy and translucent. Sweeten after it leaves the heat.

Gorgon Seed Porridge

Qian Shi Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Dried gorgon seed, often sold as fox nut, appears in Chinese food-materia-medica writing and in southern pantry practice. Older households soaked the hard kernels before adding rice so the two would soften at the same pace.

RECORD TRAIL

Food-materia-medica tradition; household proportions standardized for this edition.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 40 g dried gorgon seeds
- 60 g rice
- 1 litre water
- 10 g rock sugar, optional

TOTAL TIME

4 hours soaking, then about 55 minutes cooking

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with steady digestion and a more sustaining bowl than plain rice porridge.

CAUTION

The seeds remain firm if undercooked. Add more hot water if the pot thickens before they are tender.

METHOD

- 1 Soak the gorgon seeds in cool water for 4 hours, then drain.
- 2 Rinse the rice and place it in a pot with the soaked seeds and fresh water.
- 3 Bring to a boil, lower the heat, and simmer partly covered for 45 to 55 minutes.
- 4 Stir near the end and add rock sugar only if a sweet bowl is wanted.

Poria Steamed Cake

Fu Ling Gao

HISTORICAL RECORD

Poria powder entered both materia medica and pastry making. Thin Beijing poria wafers became the best-known commercial form, while steamed rice-flour cakes offered a simpler household version.

RECORD TRAIL

Materia medica and Beijing pastry traditions; this steamed version is an editorial household adaptation.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 30 g food-grade poria powder
- 120 g rice flour
- 25 g fine sugar
- 120 ml warm water
- 3 g neutral oil

TOTAL TIME

About 35 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with light digestion and the draining of retained dampness.

CAUTION

Use poria sold by a reputable food or herb supplier and check the label for identity and contaminants.

METHOD

- 1 Mix the poria powder, rice flour, and sugar.
- 2 Add the warm water gradually until the mixture resembles damp sand and holds when pressed.
- 3 Rub the oil over a shallow heatproof dish, press in the mixture, and level the top.
- 4 Steam over steady heat for 20 minutes, then cool for 10 minutes before cutting.

Chinese Almond Tea

Xing Ren Cha

HISTORICAL RECORD

Despite its English name, the drink is usually made from sweet apricot kernels rather than true almonds. It became a familiar northern street and home drink, thickened with rice and served hot from a ladle.

RECORD TRAIL

Northern urban food tradition; modern food-safety sourcing is essential.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 45 g commercially prepared sweet apricot kernels
- 20 g glutinous rice
- 700 ml water
- 20 g rock sugar

TOTAL TIME

2 hours soaking, then about 20 minutes cooking

Traditional effect
Traditionally associated with
moistening dryness and settling a
dry-feeling throat.

CAUTION

Use only packaged sweet apricot kernels intended for cooking. Bitter kernels can contain dangerous levels of cyanogenic compounds.

METHOD

- 1 Soak the kernels and rice separately for 2 hours, then drain.
- 2 Blend both with 300 ml of the water until very fine.
- 3 Strain through a close cloth, pressing out the liquid.
- 4 Cook the liquid with the remaining water over low heat for 12 to 15 minutes, stirring often. Add sugar at the end.

Black Rice Porridge

Hei Mi Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Black rice has long been cultivated in several Chinese regions and was valued for its colour as well as its scarcity. In home kitchens it is commonly mixed with a little glutinous rice to soften the texture and deepen the purple liquid.

RECORD TRAIL

Regional grain tradition; this ratio reflects current household porridge practice.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 70 g black rice
- 20 g glutinous rice
- 1 litre water
- 12 g brown sugar, optional

TOTAL TIME

3 hours soaking, then about 50 minutes cooking

Traditional effect

Traditionally regarded as a sustaining grain bowl associated with strength after periods of poor eating.

CAUTION

The dark pigment can stain porous utensils. People monitoring blood sugar should treat it as a full grain serving.

METHOD

- 1 Rinse both kinds of rice and soak them together for 3 hours.
- 2 Place the soaked grain and fresh water in a heavy pot.
- 3 Bring to a boil, then simmer partly covered for 45 to 50 minutes, stirring near the end.
- 4 Rest for 10 minutes before serving; add sugar only for a sweet version.

Chestnut Porridge

Li Zi Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Chestnuts moved easily between roasted street food and the family grain pot. Food records describe them as both staple and seasonal addition, especially in northern autumn kitchens.

RECORD TRAIL

Northern seasonal food tradition; modern household proportions.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 100 g peeled cooked chestnuts
- 60 g rice
- 900 ml water
- 1 g salt or 10 g brown sugar

TOTAL TIME

About 40 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with warming nourishment and physical steadiness in cool weather.

CAUTION

Chestnuts are dense in starch. Chew the pieces well and use a smaller portion for young children.

METHOD

- 1 Break the cooked chestnuts into rough pieces.
- 2 Rinse the rice and simmer it with the water for 20 minutes.
- 3 Add the chestnuts and continue cooking for 15 to 20 minutes until the grains open.
- 4 Season lightly with salt for a plain bowl or brown sugar for a sweet one.

Water Caltrop Porridge

Ling Jiao Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Water caltrops were gathered from lakes and ponds in the lower Yangzi region and sold during early autumn. Their pale, floury flesh was eaten directly or folded into rice porridge.

RECORD TRAIL

Jiangnan seasonal food record; amounts standardized for one pot.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 120 g cooked and peeled water caltrop flesh
- 60 g rice
- 900 ml water
- 10 g rock sugar, optional

TOTAL TIME

About 45 minutes after the caltrops are cooked

Traditional effect
Traditionally used to strengthen weak digestion, settle a tendency toward loose stools, and provide sustained energy without a heavily seasoned meal.

CAUTION

Freshwater plants must be thoroughly cooked. Do not eat raw water caltrops gathered from unknown water sources.

METHOD

- 1 Boil whole water caltrops until fully cooked, cool them, and remove the hard shells.
- 2 Rinse the rice and simmer it in the water for 25 minutes.
- 3 Cut the caltrop flesh into small pieces and add it to the pot.
- 4 Cook for another 12 to 15 minutes and sweeten only after the grains are soft.

Lotus Leaf Porridge

He Ye Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Lotus leaves scented rice in several southern preparations. In porridge, a food-grade dried leaf was simmered briefly and removed, leaving aroma and a pale green-brown tint rather than pieces of leaf in the bowl.

RECORD TRAIL

Southern seasonal rice practice; distinct from the lotus-root drink recorded on the website.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 8 g food-grade dried lotus leaf
- 60 g rice
- 1 litre water
- 10 g rock sugar, optional

TOTAL TIME

About 45 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with summer meals, a lighter appetite, and relief from a heavy feeling after heat.

CAUTION

Use leaves sold for food preparation, not decorative pond leaves exposed to pesticides or polluted water.

METHOD

- 1 Rinse the dried leaf quickly and place it in the water.
- 2 Simmer for 10 minutes, then lift out the leaf and strain the liquid.
- 3 Add the rinsed rice and simmer for 30 to 35 minutes.
- 4 Rest for 5 minutes and serve plain or lightly sweetened.

Dried Tangerine Peel Porridge

Chen Pi Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Aged tangerine peel was kept in southern pantry jars and used in both sweet and savoury pots. A very small amount changes the aroma of plain rice without making the porridge bitter.

RECORD TRAIL

Cantonese pantry tradition; modern one-pot ratio.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 3 g aged dried tangerine peel
- 60 g rice
- 900 ml water
- 1 g salt

TOTAL TIME

20 minutes soaking, then about 40 minutes cooking

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with easing fullness, moving stagnant food, and clearing a heavy mouth after rich meals.

CAUTION

Old peel is aromatic and bitter; increasing the amount does not make a better bowl.

METHOD

- 1 Rinse the peel and soak it in warm water for 20 minutes.
- 2 Scrape away excess white pith if the peel is very thick, then cut it into fine threads.
- 3 Cook the rice, peel, and water together at a gentle simmer for 35 to 40 minutes.
- 4 Add a small pinch of salt at the end.

White Radish Porridge

Luo Bo Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

White radish was a winter vegetable that could be grated, sliced, or cooked with grain. The porridge version used a modest amount so the radish sweetness remained after its sharp raw smell disappeared.

RECORD TRAIL

Broad winter household practice; proportions adapted for two small bowls.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 150 g peeled white radish
- 60 g rice
- 900 ml water
- 2 g salt
- 3 g sesame oil, optional

TOTAL TIME

About 40 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with easing food stagnation, belching, and a heavy feeling after rich winter dishes.

CAUTION

The bowl is light but not a substitute for assessment when abdominal pain is severe or persistent.

METHOD

- 1 Cut the radish into thin matchsticks.
- 2 Rinse the rice and simmer it in the water for 20 minutes.
- 3 Add the radish and continue cooking for 15 minutes until translucent.
- 4 Season with salt and a few drops of sesame oil.

Shepherd's Purse Porridge

Ji Cai Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Shepherd's purse is a familiar early-spring green in Jiangnan cooking. Families chopped it into dumpling fillings, tofu dishes, and rice porridge when the leaves were still tender.

RECORD TRAIL

Jiangnan spring food tradition; modern kitchen measure.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 80 g cleaned shepherd's purse
- 60 g rice
- 900 ml water
- 2 g salt
- 3 g sesame oil

TOTAL TIME

About 40 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to clear a heavy, overheated feeling, encourage urination, and ease mild puffiness after the richer foods of winter.

CAUTION

Wild greens can be misidentified or contaminated. Use cultivated produce unless identification is certain.

METHOD

- 1 Blanch the greens for 30 seconds, cool, squeeze, and chop them finely.
- 2 Simmer the rinsed rice in the water for 30 minutes.
- 3 Stir in the chopped greens and cook for another 5 minutes.
- 4 Season with salt and sesame oil just before serving.

Purslane Porridge

Ma Chi Xian Zhou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Purslane grew around fields, walls, and garden edges and entered both famine-food records and summer household cooking. Its slight sourness remained even after blanching.

RECORD TRAIL

Famine-food and summer household records; recipe standardized with cultivated purslane.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 60 g cultivated purslane
- 60 g rice
- 900 ml water
- 2 g salt

TOTAL TIME

About 40 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally associated with summer cooling and settling loose digestion.

CAUTION

Purslane is high in oxalates. People with kidney-stone risk or kidney disease should seek individual guidance before using it regularly.

METHOD

- 1 Wash the purslane repeatedly, discard tough stems, and blanch it for 1 minute.
- 2 Rinse the rice and simmer it in the water for 30 minutes.
- 3 Chop the purslane and add it for the final 5 to 7 minutes.
- 4 Season lightly with salt.

Roasted Black Soybean Tea

Hei Dou Cha

HISTORICAL RECORD

Black soybeans were roasted to deepen their aroma before being simmered or steeped. The resulting dark amber drink used a grain already present in northern and northeastern kitchens.

RECORD TRAIL

Northern grain-and-bean household practice; modern infusion ratio.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 50 g dry black soybeans
- 850 ml water

TOTAL TIME

About 35 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally associated with a sustaining drink and with relieving a puffy, water-heavy feeling.

CAUTION

Soy is a common allergen. Avoid this preparation when a soy allergy is known.

METHOD

- 1 Rinse the beans and dry them completely.
- 2 Toast them in a dry pan over medium-low heat for 8 minutes until the skins split and smell nutty.
- 3 Add the toasted beans to the water, bring to a boil, and simmer for 20 minutes.
- 4 Strain the drink; the softened beans can be added to rice rather than discarded.

Eight-Treasure Tea

Ba Bao Cha

HISTORICAL RECORD

Northwestern eight-treasure tea is as much a hospitality form as a fixed formula. Tea, fruit, seeds, and sugar were arranged visibly in a lidded cup, and the exact eight items changed with region and household means.

RECORD TRAIL

Northwestern Hui and regional tea customs; one representative household combination.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 3 g green or jasmine tea
- 6 g dried longan
- 6 g raisins
- 5 g goji berries
- 5 g walnut pieces
- 5 g sesame seeds
- 5 g dried jujube slices
- 8 g rock sugar
- 300 ml hot water

TOTAL TIME

About 8 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to relieve a dry mouth, restore fluids after travel, and provide gentle warmth and energy between meals.

CAUTION

The dried fruit and sugar make this sweeter than plain tea. Reduce the sugar when needed.

METHOD

- 1 Place the tea and dry ingredients in a lidded cup.
- 2 Add water just off the boil and cover for 5 minutes.
- 3 Stir once to loosen the sugar and drink in small pours.
- 4 Top up with hot water once or twice while the aroma remains.

Hakka Thunder Tea Rice

Lei Cha Fan

HISTORICAL RECORD

Lei cha is a pounded tea preparation associated with Hakka communities and several neighbouring groups. Herbs, tea, nuts, and seeds are ground into a paste, loosened with hot water, and served over rice with vegetables.

RECORD TRAIL

Hakka and southern regional food custom; ingredients vary widely by locality.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 8 g green tea leaves
- 20 g roasted peanuts
- 12 g toasted sesame seeds
- 20 g fresh basil or mint
- 20 g coriander
- 2 g salt
- 500 ml hot water
- 300 g cooked rice
- 200 g cooked chopped vegetables

TOTAL TIME

About 25 minutes if the rice is ready

Traditional effect

Traditionally eaten as a complete, herb-forward meal associated with appetite and recovery after physical work.

CAUTION

Contains peanuts and sesame. Use only culinary herbs that have been correctly identified.

METHOD

- 1 Pound the tea, peanuts, sesame, herbs, and salt into a coarse green paste.
- 2 Add a little hot water and continue grinding until the paste loosens.
- 3 Whisk in the remaining hot water.
- 4 Divide rice and vegetables among bowls and pour the tea mixture around them.

Beijing Flour Tea

Mian Cha

HISTORICAL RECORD

Mian cha is a thick northern breakfast bowl rather than a leaf tea. Millet flour is cooked smooth, then topped with sesame paste and a salty aromatic seasoning.

RECORD TRAIL

Beijing and Tianjin breakfast tradition; current household-scale ratio.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 45 g millet flour
- 500 ml water
- 20 g sesame paste
- 15 ml warm water
- 1 g salt
- 1 g ground fennel
- 1 g toasted sesame seeds

TOTAL TIME

About 15 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to warm a cold-feeling stomach, relieve early-morning hunger, and provide steady energy through physical work.

CAUTION

Sesame is a common allergen. The seasoning should remain light rather than heavily salted.

METHOD

- 1 Mix the millet flour with 120 ml cold water until smooth.
- 2 Bring the remaining water to a simmer and whisk in the slurry.
- 3 Cook over low heat for 6 to 8 minutes, stirring until thick.
- 4 Thin the sesame paste with warm water, spoon it over the bowl, and finish with salt, fennel, and sesame.

Northern Oil Tea

You Cha

HISTORICAL RECORD

Several northern and northwestern foods share the name you cha. In the flour-based household form, wheat flour is cooked in oil until nutty, stored dry, and later whisked with hot water.

RECORD TRAIL

Northern and northwestern flour-drink tradition; one savoury household version.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 80 g wheat flour
- 18 g sesame oil or rendered fat
- 15 g chopped walnuts
- 10 g sesame seeds
- 2 g salt
- 500 ml hot water

TOTAL TIME

About 20 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to reduce cold discomfort, warm the stomach, and provide concentrated energy during winter work or travel.

CAUTION

This is energy-dense and contains gluten, nuts, and sesame.

METHOD

- 1 Warm the oil in a heavy pan and stir in the flour.
- 2 Cook over low heat for 8 to 10 minutes until tan and nutty, then add the walnuts, sesame, and salt.
- 3 Cool the mixture if storing it.
- 4 For two bowls, whisk the toasted flour into hot water and simmer for 2 minutes.

Osmanthus Fermented Rice Soup

Gui Hua Jiu Niang

HISTORICAL RECORD

Sweet fermented rice appears in Jiangnan snacks, festival bowls, and quick household desserts. Dried osmanthus is added near the end so its scent is not boiled away.

RECORD TRAIL

Jiangnan fermented-rice tradition; household dessert ratio.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 120 g sweet fermented rice
- 450 ml water
- 5 g dried osmanthus
- 15 g rock sugar
- 1 egg, optional

TOTAL TIME

About 12 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally used to encourage appetite, ease cold-related stomach discomfort, and restore a little energy after fatigue.

CAUTION

Fermented rice can retain alcohol. Avoid it during pregnancy, for children, before driving, or when alcohol is unsuitable.

METHOD

- 1 Bring the water and rock sugar to a gentle boil.
- 2 Add the fermented rice and simmer for 3 minutes.
- 3 If using egg, pour it in as a thin stream while stirring once.
- 4 Turn off the heat, add the osmanthus, cover for 2 minutes, and serve.

Ginger Milk Curd

Jiang Zhuang Nai

HISTORICAL RECORD

This Guangdong dessert is closely associated with Shawan. Fresh ginger juice sets hot milk into a delicate curd without starch or eggs, making temperature and ginger freshness more important than stirring.

RECORD TRAIL

Shawan and Guangdong dessert tradition; modern temperature control added for repeatability.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 200 ml whole milk
- 12 g freshly pressed ginger juice
- 12 g sugar

TOTAL TIME

About 15 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally regarded as a warming
sweet that settles a cold-feeling
stomach.

CAUTION

Use pasteurized milk and clean utensils. The dessert contains dairy and may not set with old or weak ginger.

METHOD

- 1 Press fresh mature ginger and place the juice in a serving bowl.
- 2 Heat the milk with sugar to 75 to 80 C, then let it stand for 30 seconds.
- 3 Pour the milk from a little height directly into the ginger juice in one motion.
- 4 Do not stir. Cover and leave undisturbed for 8 to 10 minutes until softly set.

Dried Tangerine Peel Red Bean Soup

Chen Pi Hong Dou Sha

HISTORICAL RECORD

Cantonese sweet-soup shops and home kitchens pair adzuki beans with a small piece of aged tangerine peel. The peel is noticed first as aroma, then as a faint bitterness behind the sugar.

RECORD TRAIL

Cantonese tong sui tradition; modern household ratio.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 90 g adzuki beans
- 3 g aged dried tangerine peel
- 1 litre water
- 30 g rock sugar

TOTAL TIME

4 hours soaking, then about 70 minutes cooking

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with easing heaviness and making a bean dessert feel less cloying after a meal.

CAUTION

Serve in moderate bowls; it remains a sweet dessert even when the sugar is reduced.

METHOD

- 1 Soak the beans for 4 hours and the peel for 20 minutes.
- 2 Rinse both, cut the peel into fine threads, and place them in a pot with fresh water.
- 3 Boil, then simmer for 55 to 65 minutes until the beans break down.
- 4 Add sugar for the final 5 minutes and mash a small portion for a thicker texture.

Taro Sweet Soup

Yu Tou Tang Shui

HISTORICAL RECORD

Taro entered many southern sweet soups because it thickened the liquid as its edges softened. Some households kept the cubes intact; others deliberately mashed part of the pot.

RECORD TRAIL

Southern sweet-soup tradition; coconut milk is a later regional variation.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 250 g peeled taro
- 750 ml water
- 30 g rock sugar
- 80 ml coconut milk, optional

TOTAL TIME

About 35 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to support appetite and digestion while providing a soft, sustaining food during weakness or limited chewing.

CAUTION

Raw or undercooked taro can irritate the mouth and throat. Cook every piece until fully soft.

METHOD

- 1 Wear gloves if raw taro irritates the skin, then cut it into even cubes.
- 2 Simmer the taro in water for 22 to 25 minutes until completely tender.
- 3 Mash several cubes against the side of the pot to thicken the soup.
- 4 Add sugar and optional coconut milk, warm for 2 minutes, and serve.

Fujian Four-Fruit Soup

Si Guo Tang

HISTORICAL RECORD

Minnan four-fruit soup is a summer dessert whose name describes a changing assortment rather than four fixed ingredients. Beans, seeds, fruit, jelly, and shaved ice are combined according to the stall or household.

RECORD TRAIL

Minnan and Quanzhou summer-dessert tradition; one representative four-item combination.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 30 g dried lotus seeds
- 30 g adzuki beans
- 20 g pearl barley
- 20 g raisins
- 20 g rock sugar
- 900 ml water
- 200 g crushed ice, optional

TOTAL TIME

4 hours soaking, then about 60 minutes cooking and cooling

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to relieve thirst, cool an overheated feeling, and restore fluids and energy during humid summer weather.

CAUTION

Cook all dried beans and seeds thoroughly. Keep cooked components refrigerated and use them promptly.

METHOD

- 1 Soak the lotus seeds, beans, and barley separately for 4 hours.
- 2 Cook them in separate small pots until tender so each keeps its texture.
- 3 Dissolve the sugar in 300 ml hot water and cool the syrup.
- 4 Divide the cooked ingredients and raisins among bowls, add syrup, and serve cool or over crushed ice.

Tofu Pudding with Ginger Syrup

Jiang Zhi Dou Hua

HISTORICAL RECORD

Soft tofu pudding moves between savoury and sweet regional forms. In Cantonese sweet shops, a clear brown-sugar syrup sharpened with ginger is poured over warm douhua just before serving.

RECORD TRAIL

Cantonese sweet-shop and household tradition; modern two-bowl measure.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 300 g plain soft tofu pudding
- 20 g fresh ginger
- 35 g brown sugar
- 150 ml water

TOTAL TIME

About 15 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with warming the stomach while keeping the food soft and easy to eat.

CAUTION

Contains soy. Use freshly made or properly refrigerated tofu pudding.

METHOD

- 1 Slice or lightly crush the ginger.
- 2 Simmer it with the water and brown sugar for 8 to 10 minutes.
- 3 Warm the tofu pudding gently without boiling it.
- 4 Spoon the tofu into bowls, strain over the hot ginger syrup, and serve at once.

Folk Practices

Household materials, repeated actions, traditional effects, and the cautions that belong beside them.



The Embroidered Fragrant Sachet

Xiang Nang

HISTORICAL RECORD

Small worn pouches developed from practical carrying bags and became containers for aromatic plants. Museum and festival records connect embroidered sachets with seasonal dress, family sewing, and Duanwu customs.

RECORD TRAIL

Sachet history is documented in museum and Duanwu craft collections; this filling is a modern low-volume reconstruction.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 10 g dried tangerine peel
- 5 g dried mugwort
- 4 g whole cloves
- 3 g dried calamus
- 1 small tightly woven cloth pouch

TOTAL TIME

About 20 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally used to reduce stale household odours and discourage moths and some biting insects through the pouch's strong aromatic oils.

CAUTION

Do not ingest the filling. Keep it away from infants and pets, and omit any plant that triggers fragrance sensitivity.

METHOD

- 1 Make sure every plant material is completely dry.
- 2 Break the peel and calamus into small pieces and mix them with the mugwort and cloves.
- 3 Fill the cloth pouch without packing it tightly, then sew or tie it closed.
- 4 Hang it in an airy place and replace the contents after 4 to 6 weeks when the scent fades.

The Calamus and Mugwort Door Bundle

Chang Pu Ai Cao Men Shu

HISTORICAL RECORD

Duanwu households tied pungent calamus and mugwort near doors and windows. The plants functioned as seasonal markers, visible protective symbols, and strong-smelling additions to the early-summer house.

RECORD TRAIL

Duanwu seasonal custom; quantities describe a small household bundle, not an old fixed formula.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 60 g fresh calamus leaves
- 60 g fresh mugwort stems
- 1 length of cotton string

TOTAL TIME

About 10 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally used to freshen a damp doorway and discourage some flies and mosquitoes; hanging it at the threshold also carried a symbolic protective meaning.

CAUTION

This is a cultural doorway custom, not an air disinfectant. Keep the plants out of reach of children and animals.

METHOD

- 1 Shake dirt from the plants and wipe the stems rather than leaving them wet.
- 2 Align the cut ends and tie the bundle firmly with cotton string.
- 3 Hang it outside or beside a well-ventilated doorway for the festival day.
- 4 Remove it when the leaves wilt or show mould; do not leave a damp bundle against painted wood.

The Pomelo Leaf Bath

You Zi Ye Shui

HISTORICAL RECORD

Pomelo leaves appear in southern Chinese cleansing customs around festivals, travel, and major household transitions. The leaves were valued as much for symbolism and scent as for anything added to the water.

RECORD TRAIL

Southern ritual-washing tradition; modern dilution added for repeatability.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 35 g fresh pomelo leaves
- 1.5 litres water
- 8 litres comfortably warm bath water

TOTAL TIME

About 25 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to wash away sweat and stale body odour, leave the skin feeling fresh, and mark ritual cleansing after travel or a difficult event.

CAUTION

Citrus leaves can irritate sensitive skin. Patch test the cooled liquid and stop if itching or redness develops.

METHOD

- 1 Wash the leaves and tear each one once to release aroma.
- 2 Simmer them in 1.5 litres of water for 12 minutes.
- 3 Strain the liquid and add it to a basin of warm water.
- 4 Use the water for a brief 8 to 10 minute hand, foot, or body wash, then rinse with plain water if the skin feels sticky.

Warm Egg Rolling

Gun Ji Dan

HISTORICAL RECORD

A freshly boiled egg wrapped in cloth served as a small reusable source of warmth before manufactured gel packs were common. Households rolled it over cold hands, stiff fingers, or an unbroken bruise after the first heat had fallen.

RECORD TRAIL

Oral household heat practice; temperatures and timing standardized conservatively.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs, about 100 g total
- 1 litre water
- 1 clean cotton handkerchief

TOTAL TIME

About 18 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to provide local warmth, ease cold stiffness, and, once the early heat and swelling of a minor bruise had passed, to disperse lingering blood stasis and reduce residual puffiness.

CAUTION

Do not use during the first 48 to 72 hours after an injury or while the area is hot, red, increasingly swollen, severely painful, numb, or broken. Do not roll over a suspected fracture or unexplained bruising.

METHOD

- 1 Boil the eggs for 10 minutes until fully hard-cooked.
- 2 Cool them just enough to handle, leave the shells on, and wrap both in the folded cloth.
- 3 Test the bundle against the inside of the wrist.
- 4 Roll it lightly over intact skin for 5 minutes, stopping before the cloth cools completely.

The Warmed Sand Bag

Re Sha Dai

HISTORICAL RECORD

Clean sand held heat longer than a folded towel and was available near rivers, courtyards, and building sites. Rural households dried it thoroughly, warmed it, and enclosed it in more than one layer of cloth.

RECORD TRAIL

Rural household warming practice; the double cover is a modern safety refinement.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 350 g clean dry fine sand
- 1 inner cotton pouch
- 1 outer cotton cover

TOTAL TIME

About 15 minutes to prepare, then up to 12 minutes of use

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to improve local warmth, relax a tight-feeling muscle, and ease long-standing cold aches after the possibility of a fresh injury had been excluded.

CAUTION

Sand can become much hotter than it feels through one layer. Never sleep on the bag or use it where sensation is reduced.

METHOD

- 1 Heat the dry sand in a clean pan over low heat for 5 minutes, stirring constantly.
- 2 Transfer it to the inner pouch and close it securely.
- 3 Place that pouch inside the second cloth cover and test it against the wrist for 20 seconds.
- 4 Rest it over clothing, not bare skin, for no more than 12 minutes.

The Tangerine Peel Warm Pouch

Chen Pi Wen Dai

HISTORICAL RECORD

Dried citrus peel was repeatedly reused in southern homes: in cooking, in storage jars, and as an aromatic filling. A warmed peel pouch combined pantry thrift with short-lived dry heat.

RECORD TRAIL

Pantry-based household adaptation; not a fixed classical formula.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 80 g completely dried tangerine peel
- 1 small cotton pouch
- 1 outer cotton cloth

TOTAL TIME

About 10 minutes to prepare, then 8 minutes of use

Traditional effect
Traditionally used to ease cold-related tightness in the hands or abdomen, provide mild dry warmth, and reduce a stale or stuffy feeling through its citrus aroma.

CAUTION

Do not heat peel in a microwave unattended; dry plant material can scorch. Discard it if it smells burnt.

METHOD

- 1 Break the peel into thumb-sized pieces and check that none are damp or mouldy.
- 2 Warm the peel in a dry pan over the lowest heat for 3 minutes.
- 3 Place it in the pouch, wrap the pouch in the outer cloth, and test the temperature.
- 4 Hold it over clothing or beside the hands for up to 8 minutes.

The Roasted Black Bean Heat Bag

Hei Dou Re Dai

HISTORICAL RECORD

Beans and coarse grains were sometimes used as heat-holding fillings when sand was inconvenient. The bag could be reheated several times and eventually emptied into compost rather than stored indefinitely.

RECORD TRAIL

Grain-filled household heat bag; modern conservative timing.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 300 g dry black soybeans
- 1 tightly stitched cotton pouch
- 1 removable cotton cover

TOTAL TIME

About 12 minutes to prepare, then 10 minutes of use

Traditional effect
Traditionally used to restore warmth to cold hands and feet, relax a tense area, and ease persistent cold aches through steady dry heat.

CAUTION

Do not use beans that have become damp, rancid, or burnt. Keep the bag away from anyone with a soy allergy if dust can escape.

METHOD

- 1 Inspect the beans and remove stones or damaged pieces.
- 2 Warm them in a dry pan over low heat for 5 to 6 minutes, stirring continuously.
- 3 Transfer them to the inner pouch, add the outer cover, and test the heat carefully.
- 4 Use over clothing for up to 10 minutes and let the bag cool fully in a dry place.

The Black Tea Cooling Cloth

Hong Cha Liang Bu

HISTORICAL RECORD

Spent or inexpensive tea was rarely wasted. A cooled infusion could be used to dampen a cloth after sun, kitchen heat, or dusty work, especially when plain water alone felt too warm.

RECORD TRAIL

Twentieth-century household reuse practice; modern hygiene boundary added.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 5 g black tea leaves
- 350 ml water
- 1 clean cotton cloth

TOTAL TIME

About 20 minutes including cooling

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to cool mildly sun-warmed skin, reduce a sweaty or sticky feeling, and briefly calm minor heat-related itching on intact skin.

CAUTION

Do not place the cloth over eyes, broken skin, a serious burn, or an unexplained rash. Tea can stain pale fabric.

METHOD

- 1 Steep the tea in just-boiled water for 8 minutes.
- 2 Strain it and cool it completely to room temperature.
- 3 Soak the clean cloth, wring it until damp rather than dripping, and fold it.
- 4 Lay it on intact skin for 5 minutes, then wash the cloth.

Hibiscus Leaf Hair Wash

Mu Jin Ye Xi Fa

HISTORICAL RECORD

Fresh hibiscus leaves produce a slippery liquid when bruised in water. In parts of southern China, that plant mucilage was used as a seasonal hair wash before bottled shampoo became ordinary.

RECORD TRAIL

Southern plant-wash tradition; fresh-leaf quantity standardized for shoulder-length hair.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 50 g fresh hibiscus leaves
- 800 ml warm water

TOTAL TIME

About 25 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally associated with loosening dirt, reducing tangles, and leaving coarse hair easier to comb.

CAUTION

Correct plant identification is essential. Keep the liquid out of the eyes and stop if the scalp becomes irritated.

METHOD

- 1 Wash the leaves carefully and tear away coarse stems.
- 2 Crush the leaves in the warm water for 5 minutes until the liquid feels slippery.
- 3 Leave for 10 minutes, then strain through a close cloth.
- 4 Work the liquid through wet hair for 3 minutes and rinse thoroughly with clean water.

Tea-Seed Cake Hair Wash

Cha Zi Bing Xi Fa

HISTORICAL RECORD

The pressed cake left after extracting camellia seed oil contains natural saponins. Southern households used a small amount in washing water for hair and cloth, usually enclosed in a bag so the coarse material did not remain behind.

RECORD TRAIL

Southern oil-pressing and household-washing tradition; modern eye-safety warning retained.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 25 g crushed food-industry tea-seed cake
- 1 litre water
- 1 close-weave cloth bag

TOTAL TIME

About 30 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to remove scalp oil and stale odour, loosen surface flakes, and leave heavy hair cleaner without a separate soap bar.

CAUTION

Tea-seed saponins irritate eyes and can be harmful if swallowed. Use only identified commercial cake and keep it away from children and pets.

METHOD

- 1 Place the crushed cake in the cloth bag and tie it tightly.
- 2 Simmer the bag in the water for 12 minutes, then cool the liquid until comfortably warm.
- 3 Squeeze the bag into the water, remove it, and strain the liquid again.
- 4 Massage a small amount through wet hair for 2 minutes and rinse very thoroughly.

The Rice Bran Bath Bag

Mi Kang Yu Dai

HISTORICAL RECORD

Fresh rice bran was a milling by-product that could be enclosed in cloth and squeezed through bath water. The bag kept coarse particles out of the basin while releasing starch and oil.

RECORD TRAIL

Grain-milling household reuse; modern single-use hygiene standard.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 80 g fresh rice bran
- 1 close-weave cotton bag
- 8 litres warm water

TOTAL TIME

About 15 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to soften rough, dry-feeling skin, reduce tightness after washing, and soothe mild itching associated with dryness.

CAUTION

Rice bran spoils quickly. Prepare the bag immediately before use and discard the contents afterward.

METHOD

- 1 Smell the bran and discard it if it is stale or rancid.
- 2 Fill the bag and tie it securely.
- 3 Soak it in the warm water for 5 minutes, then squeeze it repeatedly until the water turns cloudy.
- 4 Use the water for a 7 minute hand or body wash and rinse lightly afterward.

Coix Seed Powder Wash

Yi Ren Fen Xi Mian

HISTORICAL RECORD

Finely milled grains and seeds appear in household beauty preparations as dry cleansers. Coix seed powder was mixed only when needed so it did not sour in storage.

RECORD TRAIL

Household grain-powder cleansing tradition; modern short-contact version.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 15 g finely milled food-grade coix seed
- 25 ml lukewarm water

TOTAL TIME

About 5 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with lifting surface oil and leaving the skin smooth and matte.

CAUTION

Do not use on inflamed, broken, or very dry skin.
Stop if grain particles cause redness.

METHOD

- 1 Mix the powder and water into a thin paste.
- 2 Let it stand for 1 minute so the sharp dry particles soften.
- 3 Spread it lightly over damp hands or face without hard scrubbing.
- 4 Rinse after 1 minute and pat dry.

Mung Bean Flour Wash

Lu Dou Fen Xi Mian

HISTORICAL RECORD

Mung bean flour moved beyond the cooking pot into simple household washing pastes. It was valued for its fine texture and was mixed with water rather than stored as a wet preparation.

RECORD TRAIL

Household bean-flour wash; distinct from the cooked mung-bean food article on the website.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 15 g fine mung bean flour
- 30 ml cool water

TOTAL TIME

About 4 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally associated with cooling, absorbing surface oil, and calming a hot or sticky feeling on the skin.

CAUTION

This is not for burns, infected skin, or a severe rash. Patch test if legumes have caused skin reactions before.

METHOD

- 1 Mix the flour with the water until no dry pockets remain.
- 2 Apply a thin layer to damp hands or face.
- 3 Massage very lightly for 30 seconds and leave it in place for another minute.
- 4 Rinse completely with cool water.

The Loofah Washcloth

Sì Gua Luo Bu

HISTORICAL RECORD

When a mature loofah dried on the vine, its fibrous interior could be cleaned and cut into household scrubbers. A softer piece was kept for skin while coarser sections went to pots and stove work.

RECORD TRAIL

Garden-to-household material practice; separate skin and kitchen pieces.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 1 clean dried loofah section, about 12 g and 10 cm long
- 500 ml warm water

TOTAL TIME

10 minutes soaking, then 2 minutes of use

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to remove surface dirt and loose dry skin from hard-wearing areas.

CAUTION

Do not use on the face, broken skin, or inflamed areas. Replace the loofah if it develops odour or dark spots.

METHOD

- 1 Shake out all seeds and rinse the loofah thoroughly.
- 2 Soak it in warm water for 10 minutes until flexible.
- 3 Use the softened fibres with light pressure over elbows, heels, or hands for no more than 2 minutes.
- 4 Rinse, squeeze, and dry it fully in moving air.

Camellia Oil Hair Dressing

Cha You Hu Fa

HISTORICAL RECORD

Camellia seed oil was both a cooking oil and a grooming material in southern producing regions. A very small amount was worked into wooden combs or dry hair rather than poured directly over the scalp.

RECORD TRAIL

Southern camellia-growing household practice; low-dose modern grooming measure.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 4 g food-grade camellia seed oil
- 1 wooden comb

TOTAL TIME

About 12 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally associated with reducing static, easing tangles, and giving dry hair a smoother surface.

CAUTION

Use less on fine hair and stop if the scalp reacts. Oil on floors and bath surfaces is slippery.

METHOD

- 1 Warm the oil between clean palms without heating it on the stove.
- 2 Smooth it over the last third of dry hair, concentrating on rough ends.
- 3 Wait for 8 minutes.
- 4 Comb through slowly and wash only if the hair feels heavy.

Sesame Oil Hand Wrap

Ma You Hu Shou

HISTORICAL RECORD

Kitchen oils were sometimes used on work-roughened hands before specialized creams were common. Sesame oil was used sparingly because its scent was strong and fabric held the mark.

RECORD TRAIL

Kitchen-material household grooming practice; short-contact version.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 5 g toasted or untoasted sesame oil
- 1 pair clean cotton gloves

TOTAL TIME

About 15 minutes

Traditional effect
Traditionally used to soften dry, work-roughened hands and reduce tightness after washing.

CAUTION

Do not use with sesame allergy, on open cracks, or before handling tools that require a dry grip.

METHOD

- 1 Wash and dry the hands completely.
- 2 Rub the oil between the palms and spread it over the backs of the hands and around the nails.
- 3 Put on the cotton gloves for 10 minutes.
- 4 Remove the gloves and blot away excess oil with a clean cloth.

Balsam Flower Nail Dye

Feng Xian Hua Ran Jia

HISTORICAL RECORD

Crushed garden balsam flowers were wrapped around fingernails to leave a red-orange stain. The custom appears in seasonal grooming and girls' household handwork, with alum sometimes added to deepen the colour.

RECORD TRAIL

Seasonal Chinese nail-dye custom; the colour varies with flower and contact time.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 25 g fresh garden balsam petals
- 1 g powdered alum
- 10 small leaf or cotton squares
- 10 short cotton ties

TOTAL TIME

About 20 minutes preparation and 2 hours dyeing

Traditional effect

Its reliable effect was a durable red-orange stain. Folk households also applied the alum-and-flower paste to thick or discoloured nail surfaces, although that historical use does not establish that it changes a nail disorder.

CAUTION

Alum and plant sap can irritate skin. Patch test first, do not use on damaged cuticles, and stop if burning occurs.

METHOD

- 1 Wash and dry the petals, then crush them with the alum into a wet pulp.
- 2 Place a small amount over each clean nail, avoiding the surrounding skin as much as possible.
- 3 Cover with a leaf or cotton square and tie gently.
- 4 Leave for up to 2 hours, remove the wraps, and rinse the hands.

The Boxwood Comb Routine

Huang Yang Mu Shu Fa

HISTORICAL RECORD

Fine-toothed wooden combs were grooming tools, personal objects, and gifts. Daily combing distributed hair oil and removed dust at a time when full hair washing was less frequent.

RECORD TRAIL

Longstanding personal-grooming object; timing reflects a practical daily routine rather than a fixed old count.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 1 smooth boxwood comb, about 25 g
- 1 clean cotton cloth

TOTAL TIME

About 6 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to distribute natural hair oil, loosen small tangles, stimulate a tight-feeling scalp, and reduce the discomfort of hair pulled into a fixed style.

CAUTION

Do not share combs during a scalp infection or lice outbreak. Replace any comb with cracked or sharp teeth.

METHOD

- 1 Wipe the comb teeth with the cloth and check for splinters.
- 2 Detangle the ends first, then move gradually toward the roots.
- 3 Comb from the hairline toward the back in slow passes for about 5 minutes without scraping the scalp.
- 4 Wipe the comb clean and store it dry.

Willow Twig Tooth Cleaning

Liu Zhi Jie Chi

HISTORICAL RECORD

Chewing sticks predate the modern toothbrush and appear across Asia. In Chinese records, willow and other suitable twigs were softened and frayed so one end acted as a small brush.

RECORD TRAIL

Historical chewing-stick practice; species identification and one-use hygiene are modern safeguards.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 1 pesticide-free young willow twig, about 8 g and 15 cm long
- 250 ml boiled and cooled water

TOTAL TIME

30 minutes soaking, then 2 minutes of use

Traditional effect

Historically used to remove visible food and leave a fresh woody taste before manufactured brushes were available.

CAUTION

This is a historical record, not a replacement for a modern soft toothbrush, fluoride toothpaste, flossing, or dental care. Do not use an unidentified twig.

METHOD

- 1 Wash the twig and soak it in the water for 30 minutes.
- 2 Chew one end gently until the fibres separate.
- 3 Use the softened fibres with light pressure over the tooth surfaces, not under the gumline.
- 4 Discard the twig after one use and rinse the mouth with plain water.

Fine Salt Tooth Powder

Xi Yan Jie Chi

HISTORICAL RECORD

Salt appears in many early household cleaning practices because it was dry, portable, and mildly abrasive. On teeth it was used in very small amounts, long before modern enamel-safe pastes existed.

RECORD TRAIL

Historical household cleaning material; deliberately limited here to explain the practice without recommending repeated use.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 1 g very finely ground table salt
- 1 soft damp toothbrush

TOTAL TIME

About 30 seconds

Traditional effect

Historically associated with scouring away visible residue and reducing food odour in the mouth.

CAUTION

Frequent salt scrubbing can irritate gums and wear tooth surfaces. Modern fluoride toothpaste is the appropriate routine choice.

METHOD

- 1 Wet the toothbrush and touch only the tips of the bristles to the salt.
- 2 Brush the visible tooth surfaces with very light pressure for no more than 30 seconds.
- 3 Rinse thoroughly with plain water.
- 4 Treat this as a historical demonstration, not a daily routine.

The Rice Vinegar Cup

Mi Cu Zhi E

HISTORICAL RECORD

A sharp sour swallow was one of several table-side actions used when hiccups interrupted a meal. Families also tried breath holding, a sudden question, or a sip of warm water; no single action belonged to every region.

RECORD TRAIL

Table-side oral custom; dilution added to reduce irritation.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 5 ml plain rice vinegar
- 15 ml lukewarm water

TOTAL TIME

Less than 2 minutes

Traditional effect

Traditionally intended to interrupt a brief run of hiccups through a strong sour taste and deliberate swallow.

CAUTION

Avoid with reflux, ulcers, swallowing difficulty, or vinegar sensitivity. Persistent hiccups require professional assessment.

METHOD

- 1 Dilute the vinegar with the lukewarm water in a small cup.
- 2 Take one slow sip rather than swallowing it undiluted.
- 3 Pause and breathe normally for 1 minute.
- 4 Do not repeat the cup if it causes burning, nausea, or reflux.

The Camphorwood Wardrobe Sachet

Zhang Mu Yi Gui Dai

HISTORICAL RECORD

Camphorwood chests and small wood pieces were used in clothing storage for their strong scent. A removable pouch allowed households to keep chips away from direct contact with pale fabric.

RECORD TRAIL

Camphorwood storage tradition; pouch and ventilation are practical modern boundaries.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 30 g clean untreated camphorwood chips
- 1 tightly woven cotton pouch

TOTAL TIME

About 10 minutes, then 6 to 8 weeks in storage

Traditional effect
Traditionally associated with keeping stored clothing dry-smelling and discouraging fabric insects.

CAUTION

Do not ingest camphorwood or place it where children or pets can chew it. Avoid use around people with fragrance-triggered symptoms.

METHOD

- 1 Confirm that the chips are untreated camphorwood, not loose synthetic camphor crystals.
- 2 Place them in the pouch and sew or tie it closed.
- 3 Set the pouch on a small dish or hang it inside a ventilated clothing chest.
- 4 Air the chest and replace the chips when the scent fades.

The Salt and Tea Deodorizing Jar

Yan Cha Chu Wei Guan

HISTORICAL RECORD

Small open dishes of dry pantry material were used in cupboards and shoe cabinets when washing the entire space was impractical. Salt absorbed some moisture while dry tea leaves supplied scent.

RECORD TRAIL

Pantry-material household practice; one-week limit added for cleanliness.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 100 g coarse salt
- 12 g completely dry spent tea leaves
- 1 wide ceramic jar

TOTAL TIME

About 5 minutes, then up to 7 days in place

Traditional effect

Traditionally used to make small closed storage spaces smell less stale and feel less damp.

CAUTION

This does not remove mould or a serious moisture source. Clean and dry the space properly if dampness continues.

METHOD

- 1 Dry the spent tea leaves fully in moving air or a very low oven.
- 2 Mix them with the coarse salt and place the mixture in the open jar.
- 3 Set the jar where it cannot be knocked over, away from food preparation.
- 4 Discard the mixture after 7 days or sooner if it becomes damp.

Dried Tangerine Peel Foot Water

Chen Pi Pao Jiao Shui

HISTORICAL RECORD

Dried citrus peel often moved from the pantry jar into wash water after its best cooking aroma had faded. The practice combined thrift, fragrance, and the established evening basin routine.

RECORD TRAIL

Southern pantry-and-basin custom; distinct from the website's mugwort and peppercorn foot-soak records.

MEASURED INGREDIENTS

- 20 g dried tangerine peel
- 1.5 litres water
- 3 litres additional warm water

TOTAL TIME

About 30 minutes including a 10 minute soak

Traditional effect

Traditionally associated with warming cold feet, reducing a stale shoe smell, and giving evening water a clean citrus aroma.

CAUTION

Do not use very hot water, broken citrus peel on broken skin, or a shared basin during a foot infection.

METHOD

- 1 Rinse the peel and simmer it in 1.5 litres of water for 12 minutes.
- 2 Strain the liquid into a foot basin and add enough warm water to reach a comfortable temperature.
- 3 Soak clean feet for 10 minutes.
- 4 Dry carefully, especially between the toes, and wash the basin.

Where the historical record begins

This edition uses historical texts, academic histories, museum object records, and regional food records as separate kinds of evidence. A museum object can establish that a vessel existed; it cannot by itself establish every use later attributed to it. A materia medica can establish a written association; it does not turn that association into a modern guarantee.

National Library of Medicine

Traditional Chinese Medicine: historical texts and collections

<https://www.nlm.nih.gov/hmd/topics/chinese-traditional/>

National Library of Medicine catalogue

Ben Cao Gang Mu: complete Chinese text and research record

<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/nlmcatalog/497846>

Wellcome Collection

Chinese household and lay-practice manuscript collections

<https://wellcomecollection.org/works/hsv6xgux>

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Early Chinese medical literature: the Mawangdui manuscripts

<https://wellcomecollection.org/works/m6972qq7>

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Medieval Chinese medicine: the Dunhuang manuscripts

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National Center for Biotechnology Information

A concise classification of bencao literature

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5894148/>

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The food-medicine continuum in historical context

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9975626/>

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Historical edible use of kudzu

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12287102/>

Smithsonian Folklife Festival

Sachets from Gansu Province

<https://festival.si.edu/2014/china/through-the-seasons/sachets/smithsonian>

Beijing University of Chinese Medicine Museum

History of Chinese fragrant sachets

<https://bowuguan.bucm.edu.cn/kpzl/ysmt/39443.htm>

UNESCO

Traditional tea processing techniques and associated social practices in China

<https://ich.unesco.org/en/RL/o1884>

Keep the record distinct

A household action can be historically important without being universal. A food can belong to one region and be unknown in another. A plant can appear in an old text while the household ratio printed here is modern. Those distinctions are part of the record and should remain visible.